In my view it was geographical access to three important resources—rice, trade and iron. The kingdom not only had control over very fertile lands but was also served by a number of rivers including the Ganga itself. Thus, it would have had the agricultural muscle to support a large army. Moreover, the kingdom controlled the trade plying the Uttara Path between the North West and the emerging sea-ports of Bengal. Add to this, access to iron ore from what is now Jharkhand. In order to appreciate this conjunction of circumstances, consider the location of the kingdom's first capital, Rajgir (also referred to as Rajagriha or King's Home). Defended by hills, it sits strategically between the fertile farmlands to the north and the mines of the south. In short, Magadh was uniquely able to feed large armies and arm them with iron weapons. This explains why Magadh would be at the heart of the next stage in Indian history.

ENTER THE LION

India is the only country in the world where both lions and tigers co-exist. As discussed in Chapter 1, tigers evolved in East Asia and probably entered the subcontinent around 12,000 years ago. Soon, they had spread across the subcontinent. They are commonly represented in Harappan art and seals. In sharp contrast, the Harappans appear to be ignorant of the lion! None of the main Harappan sites have thrown up any representation of the lion. This is very odd given the obvious appeal of the animal and its importance in later Indian culture. The tiger hunts by stealth in dense jungle and, therefore, is more of an object of fear. In contrast, the lion with its shaggy mane, its harem of lionesses, and its confident visibility is easily converted into a symbol of power.

Every culture that has encountered the lion has tended to give the animal a special status. Even in countries that have never had a lion population, such as Britain and China, the lion has been part of imperial symbolism. We know that lions were considered royal game in Mesopotamia in the second millennium BC and only the king could hunt them. [8] In ancient Egypt too, lion hunting was a royal prerogative. Amentohep III (1391-1352 BC) killed